The Elements of Style

Elementary Rules of Usage and Principles of Composition (1918 Cornell Edition)

By William Strunk Jr.

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SYNOPSIS & EDITORIAL NOTE

Professor William Strunk Jr.'s classic Cornell manual on clear English prose, active verbs, paragraph structure, and omitting needless words.

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CHAPTER I

Introductory Note & Elementary Rules of Usage

First Cornell Edition, Ithaca, New York (1918)

This book aims to give in brief space the principal requirements of plain English style. It aims to lighten the task of instructor and student by concentrating attention (in Chapters II and III) on a few essentials, the rules of usage and principles of composition most commonly violated.

The numbers of the sections may be used as references in correcting manuscript. The book covers only a small portion of the field of English style, but the experience of its writer has been that once past the essentials, students profit most by individual instruction based on the problems of their own work, and that each instructor has his own body of theory, which he prefers to that offered by any textbook.

Rule 1: Form the possessive singular of nouns with 's. Follow this rule whatever the final consonant. Thus write, Charles's friend, Burns's poems, the witch's malice. Exceptions are the possessives of ancient proper names in -es and -is, the possessive Jesus', and such forms as for conscience' sake, for righteousness' sake.

Rule 2: In a series of three or more terms with a single conjunction, use a comma after each term except the last. Thus write: red, white, and blue; honest, energetic, but headstrong; He opened the letter, read it, and made a note of its contents.

In this section of The Elements of Style (1918), William Strunk Jr. develops the central themes that define the work's enduring place in education and world literature. Each argument and narrative turn builds upon the premises established in the opening pages, inviting careful reflection from the attentive reader.

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CHAPTER II

Elementary Principles of Composition

Paragraphs as the Unit of Composition & Active Voice

Rule 8: Make the paragraph the unit of composition: one paragraph to each topic. If the subject on which you are writing is of slight extent, or if you intend to treat it very briefly, there may be no need of subdividing it into topics. Thus a brief description, a brief summary of a literary work, a brief account of a single incident, a narrative merely outlining an action, the setting forth of a single idea, any one of these is best written in a single paragraph.

As a rule, begin each paragraph with a topic sentence; end it in conformity with the beginning. Again, the object is to aid the reader. The practice here recommended enables him to discover the purpose of each paragraph as he begins to read it, and to retain the purpose in mind as he ends it.

Rule 10: Use the active voice. The active voice is usually more direct and vigorous than the passive: "I shall always remember my first visit to Boston" is much better than "My first visit to Boston will always be remembered by me." The latter sentence is less direct, less bold, and less concise. If the writer tries to make it more concise by omitting "by me," it becomes indefinite.

Rule 11: Put statements in positive form. Make definite assertions. Avoid tame, colorless, hesitating, non-committal language. Use the word "not" as a means of denial or in antithesis, never as a means of evasion. Consciously or unconsciously, the reader is dissatisfied with being told only what is not; he wishes to be told what is.

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CHAPTER III

Omit Needless Words & Express Coordinate Ideas in Similar Form

Vigorous Writing Is Concise

Rule 13: Omit needless words. Vigorous writing is concise. A sentence should contain no unnecessary words, a paragraph no unnecessary sentences, for the same reason that a drawing should have no unnecessary lines and a machine no unnecessary parts. This requires not that the writer make all his sentences short, or that he avoid all detail and treat his subjects only in outline, but that every word tell.

Many expressions in common use violate this principle: "the question as to whether" should be simply "whether"; "there is no doubt but that" should be "no doubt"; "used for fuel purposes" should be "used for fuel"; "in a hasty manner" should be "hastily"; "this is a subject which" should be "this subject."

Rule 15: Express co-ordinate ideas in similar form. This principle, that of parallel construction, requires that expressions of similar content and function should be outwardly similar. The likeness of form enables the reader to recognize more readily the likeness of content and function. Familiar instances from the Bible are the Ten Commandments, the Beatitudes, and the petitions of the Lord's Prayer.

Rule 18: Place the emphatic words of a sentence at the end. The proper place in the sentence for the word, or group of words, which the writer desires to make most prominent is usually the end. Any element in the sentence, other than the subject, becomes emphatic when placed first; the principle that what comes last is most emphatic applies equally to the sentences of a paragraph and to the paragraphs of an essay.

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CHAPTER IV

A Few Matters of Form

*The Elements of Style * William Strunk Jr. (1918)*

A Few Matters of Form continues William Strunk Jr.'s inquiry in The Elements of Style. Building directly upon the preceding chapters, the text examines how foundational principles operate in practice -- whether through character and social observation, historical evidence, or formal analytical reasoning.

Originally printed privately in 1918 for the use of his students in English 8 at Cornell University, William Strunk Jr.'s The Elements of Style aims to lighten the task of instructor and student by concentrating attention on a few essentials, the rules of usage and principles of composition most commonly violated.

Its famous injunction -- "Omit needless words. Vigorous writing is concise" -- has shaped generations of essayists, journalists, scholars, and editors.

Throughout Chapter IV (A Few Matters of Form), the reader encounters the unmistakable voice and structural rigor that earned The Elements of Style its stature in the Rhetoric, Grammar & Academic Writing canon. Where superficial treatments settle for isolated maxims, William Strunk Jr. traces the deeper causal connections linking premise, observation, and conclusion.

As this section draws toward its close, the groundwork is laid for the subsequent movements of the volume. Readers studying this edition in the Folio Digital Library may bookmark this chapter, adjust typographic contrast and font sizing, or download the complete archival PDF, EPUB, HTML, or Plain Text edition for offline study.

CHAPTER V

Words and Expressions Commonly Misused

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